



Rush HOUR

Global auto majors line up the latest models and big bucks for investment in new plants as they look to carve out market shares in the roaring Indian auto mart

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Indians love cars, and carmakers, it is clear, love India. Virtually every brand is looking for a parking spot in the Indian market and is lining up new models, investments and, of course, special sentiments to edge out competition. Volvo splashed the special XC90 on over 2,000 screens through the Bollywood blockbuster *3 Idiots*. Volkswagen flew down virtu-

ally its marquee of international executives for the Auto Expo in Delhi. BMW India President Peter Kronschnabl greeted the audience with perfect, even if a bit anglicised, "*Namaskar, BMW pavilion mein aapka swagat hai*". The promise and potential of India and its growing stature has only been too obvious at the Expo, which has recorded the largest ever overseas participation this year from Canada, China, Finland, France, Germany, Italy, Japan, Spain, Taiwan and the

UK. Pawan Goenka, president, Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers (SIAM), points out that for the first time, 10 manufacturers showcased their global products, including Honda's concept car and Toyota's small car.

Clearly, India is now on the road map of every auto-maker in the world, thanks to the spectacular 21-plus per cent growth in car sales amidst the meltdown. It is not just gestures or words that they bring along; there is a plan. "Audi has a 10-year plan for